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THE ROUND TABLE CONFERENCE

In a recent book an English journalist, who claims to have seen a great deal of Mr. Gandhi both in India and at the Round Table Conference in London, writes as follows:

"The leaders on board the *Mooltan* knew that there was a conspiracy against Mr. Gandhi within the Congress Working Committee. They knew that, when the time was ripe, Congress might expel him. But Congress, by expelling Mr. Gandhi, would expel in all probability half its members; and that was the half Sir Tej Bahadur Sapru and Mr. Jayakar wished to attach to the Liberal cause. They never disguised the fact that Mr. Gandhi was, in their own words, 'muddle-headed'. It was worth winning a 'muddle-headed' leader when he could bring with him a million 'muddle-headed' followers." [1]

I do not know how far this quotation represents the views of Sir Tej Bahadur Sapru, Mr. Jayakar, or the other members of the R.T.C. on their way to London in 1931. But it does seem to me an astonishing thing that any person, journalist or 'leader', with the least acquaintance with Indian politics, could have made such a statement. I was astounded to read it; I had not heard of it previously even as a suggestion, though that is not difficult to understand, as I have been in prison for most of the time since then.

Who were the conspirators and what were they after? It was sometimes stated that the President, Vallabhbhai Patel, and I

[1] From Glorney Bolton's *The Tragedy of Gandhi*. I have taken this extract from a review of the book, as I have had no opportunity so far of reading the book itself. I hope that I am not doing an injustice thereby to the author or to the persons mentioned in the quotation. . . . Since writing the above I have read the book. Many of the statements of Mr. Bolton and the inferences he draws are, to my thinking, wholly unjustified. There are also a number of errors of fact, especially in regard to what the Working Committee did or did not do during the Delhi Pact negotiations and after. There is also a curious assumption that Mr. Vallabhbhai Patel got the Congress presidentship in 1931, and thereby the leadership of the Congress, in rivalry with Mr. Gandhi. As a matter of fact, during the last fifteen years Mr. Gandhi has been a far bigger person in the Congress (and, of course, in the country) than any Congress Presi-